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Celtics trade away Brown to rival 76ers

Blockbuster deal ends All-Star's hugely successful career with Boston

By Adam Himmelsbach
GLOBE STAFF

In a seismic, franchise-altering move, the Celtics on Wednesday agreed to trade franchise cornerstone Jaylen Brown, the 2024 NBA Finals MVP, to the rival 76ers in exchange for veteran forward Paul George, 2028 and 2031 first-round picks, and two future second-round picks, according to multiple league sources.

It marks a sudden end to the

Boston tenure of Brown, who finished sixth in MVP voting this past season and became one of the best players in franchise history.

News of the deal sent shockwaves through the NBA and rattled a puzzled Celtics fan base Wednesday. One league source said Boston's brass agonized for days over the decision to trade Brown, but eventually determined that acquiring valuable assets along with a nine-time All-Star in George of-

fered the franchise its best path forward.

Last month, Brown was the centerpiece of the Celtics' trade offer for Bucks superstar Giannis Antetokounmpo. Milwaukee ultimately sent the two-time MVP to the Heat for a package of young players and draft picks. Celtics president of basketball operations Brad Stevens later fielded questions about Brown's status and stopped short of saying the forward would remain in Boston.

"Jaylen Brown is a big part of us," Stevens said then. "I'm never



Jaylen Brown was the 2024 NBA Finals MVP.

BROWN, Page C3

Sewage pollution not a new problem

EPA had ordered fixes in Haverhill a decade ago

By Sabrina Shankman
GLOBE STAFF

and Audrey Tomlin and Thai Theodoro
GLOBE CORRESPONDENTS

A decade before a sewer main broke in Haverhill last Friday, dumping untreated sewage into the Merrimack River and making North Shore beaches unswimmable, city officials signed a consent de-

►Sewage overflow halted; some beaches are reopened to swimmers. B2.

cree with the US Environmental Protection Agency in which they agreed to take critical steps to prevent additional pollution of the river.

The agreement, which also included state officials, required Haverhill to upgrade its sewer system and treatment plant to address a persistent problem: aging infrastructure that dumped polluted storm water containing sewage directly into the Merrimack River watershed 190 times.

"We are pleased that, through this settlement, steps will be taken to better protect ... the Merrimack and Little Rivers," said Maura Healey, at the time the attorney general of Massachusetts.

Except the discharges continued, to the point where in all but three of the last 10 years, Haverhill released an even greater volume of so-called combined sewage overflow than it did in 2016, when

SEWAGE, Page A7

AUDIENCE OF NONE



Classical groups try new programming, pricing — anything else that might fill seats

By A.Z. Madonna
GLOBE STAFF

Sarah Darling has been playing violin and viola professionally in Boston for over two decades. In that time, she's stood on a lot of stages and looked out over a lot of audiences — and she can't remember when she started noticing so many empty seats.

Maybe it was before the pandemic, or maybe shortly after. But the realization felt like a "slow-moving sense of shock," she said. She had been accustomed to fuller houses when some of her groups played. Then, without any clear-cut reason, the crowds were dwindling.

It's news to no one that attendance at classical performances has been broadly on the decline for years, even decades. But recently, the numbers have become alarming to musicians and presenting organizations alike. Across the United States, according to the National



TURNING THE MUSIC DOWN

Percentage of American adults who attended a live classical performance in:

2017
8.6%
vs.
2022
4.6%

Endowment for the Arts, the percentage of American adults who attended a live classical performance plummeted from 8.6 in 2017 to 4.6 in 2022, the most recent years the Survey for Public Participation in the Arts was conducted.

In Boston, a city practically defined by its cultural institutions, attendance appears to have likewise slumped. Local attendance data is not readily available, but the city's premier classical organization, the Boston Symphony Orchestra, has cited a 40 percent decline across the past 20 years — with a dramatic downturn after the pandemic — as impetus behind a controversial effort to overhaul future programming. Many other classical ensembles are coping with diminished numbers as well and are likewise taking steps to lure new audiences. The question they all face is how to do it.

CLASSICAL, Page A10

BECMA keeps up fight for Black business

Focuses on growth through advocacy, support, funding

By Katie Johnston
GLOBE STAFF

In the spring of 2015, a group of Black leaders gathered around a table at the former Darryl's Corner Bar & Kitchen in the South End to discuss the state of Boston's Black business community.

The Federal Reserve Bank of Boston had just released a groundbreaking study showing that Black households in the area had a median net worth of just \$8, and the people at that table were intent on addressing this dismal finding. That fall, they formed the Black Economic Council of Massachusetts, or BECMA, dedicated to building wealth in the Black community.

The nonprofit has been relentlessly focused on that goal since, even as current headwinds make the work harder than ever.

BECMA filed a federal civil rights complaint in 2021 alleging the city discriminated against Black and Latino businesses. The complaint led to a more diverse slate of city contractors. The council also pushed state legislators to create benchmarks and pilot programs that benefited employers of color, and rallied Black business owners to testify

BECMA, Page A10

On July 4, his business is booming

Fireworks display for 250th will be biggest ever in Boston

By Camilo Fonseca
GLOBE STAFF

When he looks up at the blue sky over the Charles River, Matt Shea thinks in terms of flowers.

"Your principal ones are chrysanthemums and peonies, OK," he said, brow furrowed and eyes against the sun. "And then your dahlias and willows. They all kind of mimic that, what you see in your head."

Shea is not, in fact, talking about actual flowers, but the images of ones created by the fusillade of pyrotechnics he will set off Saturday night to dramatically mark the conclusion of the Boston Pops Fireworks Spectacular along the Esplanade and Charles River.

That performance will be the biggest fireworks display Boston will have ever seen, with 4,500 individual explosions in honor of the country's 250th anniversary. And for the first time, according to organizers, those fireworks will be choreographed to live music from the Boston Pops.

The fireworks, fired by radio control from mortars on barges moored in the middle of the river, are meticulously set up,

FIREWORKS, Page A6



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Of overseeing the fireworks, Matt Shea said: "How could I say that I'm not absolutely thrilled to be a part of it?"



Of humid events

Thursday: Very hot.
High: 96-101. Low: 80-85.

Friday: Still hot, storm possible.
High: 95-100. Low: 75-80.

Sunrise: 5:12 Sunset: 8:25
Comics and Weather, D5-6.

Obituaries, C9.

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President Trump reaped a stunning windfall in his first year back in the White House, including about \$1.4 billion from his family's cryptocurrency businesses, a new filing shows. A2.

A group of traditionalist Catholics consecrated four bishops in defiance of a plea from Pope Leo XIV, creating the biggest internal crisis of his young papacy. A4.

State lawmakers are entering their final stretch of formal sessions this month with a lot left to do. B1.

Nursing home executives collected hefty paychecks as they understaffed their Massachusetts facilities, leading to life-threatening injuries to their patients, according to a settlement agreement. D1.